

Learn to Be a Great Communicator: Wrap-Up, Featuring Virginia Means

Virginia Means, Chief People Officer, United Distributors, Inc.

Coach Summitt said, “Communication is not just about giving great speeches. It’s about allowing others to express themselves.” Effective communication is about more than just exchanging information. Let’s take a look back at several characteristics highlighted by John Horton that can apply to increasing understanding and communication.

Great communicators are authentic, place high value on relationships, and are also aware of the impact of their nonverbal communication, body language, eye contact, etc.

Authenticity matters a lot. Leaders must be open and transparent and find their own authentic voice. Bring who you are, where you come from, and what you value into your communication.

Consider this: 161 players played for Coach Summitt. Of those, 74 became coaches themselves. Forty-six percent of Coach Summitt’s student athletes followed in her footsteps. Relationships and authenticity are the only way to explain such a staggering number of individuals following Pat into the coaching ranks.

But remember, it’s not just your words that matter. A great deal of communication comes through nonverbal communication. If we’re not aware of the nonverbal communication, it can be easy to misunderstand the message. As humans, when we’re unsure about what the words mean, we pay more attention to the non-verbal signs, cues, and expressions. So, be aware of the message you may be sending with your nonverbal communication. Pat’s famous stare is one of the clearest nonverbal examples ever sent.

In the end, always remember John (Horton’s) communication maxim: short is better than long. Simple is better than complex. Truth and authenticity are more important than everything else.